Zheyuan (Kevin) Cui

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Placement

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References

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Professor Moritz Lenel
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Education

2021 – 2027 (Expected)	**Princeton University** Ph.D. Candidate in Economics, Bendheim Center for Finance Expected Graduation: May 2027	Princeton, NJ, USA
2019 – 2021	**University of California – Los Angeles** M.A. in Mathematics (Ph.D. Course Track)	Los Angeles, CA, USA
2017 – 2021	**University of California – Los Angeles** B.S. in Applied Mathematics (Highest Honor), Economics (Highest Honor)	Los Angeles, CA, USA

Research Interests

Asset Pricing, Fixed Income, Financial Intermediary, AI & Productivity

Job Market Paper

Tax Heterogeneity, Duration Risk, and the Term Structure: An Application to the Municipal Bond Puzzle [Link to Paper] [SSRN]

Abstract: I develop a term-structure model in which investors with heterogeneous taxes and balance sheets jointly choose taxable and tax-exempt bonds across maturities under short-sale constraints. These differences endogenously segment ownership and shape both yield curves.

The model explains the municipal bond puzzle: short tax-exempt municipal yields closely match taxable yields after the highest household tax rates, while thirty-year yields exceed this benchmark by 118 basis points, implying lower marginal tax rates. Lower-tax investors whose liabilities hedge interest-rate risk bear duration risk more cheaply than households and hold long municipal bonds despite smaller exemption benefits. Long yields therefore reflect their lower taxes. Without targeting municipal yields, the calibrated model explains 83 percent of this puzzle. Using cross-state differences in home-state tax exemptions and a discontinuity in a bank-only tax benefit, I find that household taxes are almost fully priced in short municipal yields but less in long ones, while banks' benefit is priced mainly in long yields, as the model predicts. Counterfactuals show how tax reforms affect financing costs in both markets through portfolio substitution.

Publication

The Effects of Generative AI on High-Skilled Work: Evidence from Three Field Experiments with Software Developers *with Mert Demirer, Sonia Jaffe, Leon Musolff, Sida Peng, Tobias Salz.* [Link to Paper] [Journal Page]

Coverage: *New York Times, 2025 Economic Report of the President*
***Management Science*, Forthcoming**

Abstract: This study evaluates the effect of generative AI on software developer productivity via randomized controlled trials at Microsoft, Accenture, and an anonymous Fortune 100 company. These field experiments, run by the companies as part of their ordinary course of business, provided a random subset of developers with access to an AI-based coding assistant suggesting intelligent code completions. Though each experiment is noisy and results vary across experiments, when data is combined across three experiments and 4,867 developers, our analysis reveals a 26.08% increase (SE: 10.3%) in completed tasks among developers using the AI tool. Notably, less experienced developers had higher adoption rates and greater productivity gains.

Working Papers

Overvalued Geographic Familiarity in International Equity Management *with Yinan Qiu.* [Link to Paper]

Abstract: Foreign education may provide country-specific expertise, but its value across international portfolios is less clear. Within funds over time and across similar funds, greater foreign-educated representation is associated with lower factor-adjusted net returns. High-conviction holdings in managers' education countries earn high alphas, but contribute little to portfolio alpha at actual weights. Outside these countries, foreign-educated teams select stocks less successfully in markets bordering or more socially connected to their education countries, where familiarity is expected to help. We connect these investment patterns to how funds recruit and evaluate managers. Funds are more likely to hire managers educated in a country after their holdings there underperform. These appointments are followed by short-lived local improvements. More broadly, foreign-educated recruits bring weaker prior team investment records than U.S.-educated recruits, and foreign-educated managers' retention is less sensitive to deteriorating fund performance than that of U.S.-educated colleagues. Together, the findings suggest that funds credit geographic familiarity more broadly than demonstrated investment performance warrants.

How Hidden Local Government Debt Shapes Shadow Banking Competition: Evidence from Wealth Management in China *with Tao Shen, Tianqi Zhi.* [Link to Paper]

Abstract: Using granular holdings data on China's RMB 33 trillion market for wealth-management

products operated by banks or their subsidiaries, we study how government support for borrowers shapes competition in shadow banking. Smaller banks sought an edge over larger rivals by reaching for yield in home-province bonds issued by local government financing vehicles (LGFVs). The 2023 debt resolution initiative strengthened expected support for LGFVs and compressed their bond spreads. The estimated product-return premium associated with home LGFV bonds fell by 69%. Larger local banks expanded into higher-yielding, LGFV-linked private credit, while smaller banks substituted little and lost ground in relative product returns and wealth-management balances. Our model explains this unequal adjustment through fixed contracting costs that make investment scale important. Government support for borrowers can thus erode smaller banks' competitive edge and shift shadow banking toward larger intermediaries and more opaque credit.

Work in Progress

The Limits of Debt Discipline: Risk-Based Regulation and Shadow Finance *with Tao Shen, Wei Xiong, Tianqi Zhi.*

Abstract: We study whether risk-based regulation makes public debt safer or simply shifts it to other regions and costlier lenders. China caps bond borrowing by local government financing vehicles (LGFVs) in high-risk regions, then refinanced their debt in 2023, mostly in those same regions. We find that this discipline largely moves the borrowing rather than removing it. First, it moves across regions. Borrowing slows in high-risk regions, which later grow more slowly, but keeps rising in regions seen as fiscally stronger despite low investment returns. Second, it moves into shadow finance. LGFVs facing rating-based bond limits turn to costly nonstandard loans from trusts and leasing companies. After the 2023 relief, their nonstandard rates rose 176 basis points relative to their bond rates. Relief aimed at the riskiest regions also invites moral hazard, as less-relieved regions keep expanding this costly nonstandard debt. Discipline can make the bond market look safe while risk builds where it is costlier and harder to see.

Teaching Experience

Chinese Financial and Monetary Systems (ECO 494/FIN 594) Princeton University
Fall 2026, Fall 2024, Fall 2023 (Prof. Wei Xiong)

Introduction to Macroeconomics (ECO 101) Princeton University
Spring 2026, Spring 2025, Spring 2024 (Prof. Richard Rogerson)
Fall 2023 (Dr. Henry Shim)

Internship Experience

Jun – Aug 2025 **Susquehanna International Group (SIG)** Bala Cynwyd, PA, USA
Quantitative Researcher Intern

Jun – Aug 2023 **Microsoft Research** Cambridge, MA, USA
Research Intern

Languages

Chinese (native), English (fluent)
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